



Utopias and Their Pursuit: A Comparative Study of the East and West 理想社会与其实践: 东西方历史的跨文化对话

Dec 20-22, 2025
Notre Dame Beijing

This conference aims to examine the utopian ideals and their practical manifestations by bringing Chinese and Catholic thought and historical experience into conversation. Major religions and spiritual traditions have their own forms of utopia, which have shaped the foundational pillars of political and social values in their respective civilizations. This conference includes philosophical and theological elaborations and critiques of utopia; policies and historical events guided by utopian ideals; and ways utopias inform current world discourse.

Organizers:

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Utopias and Their Pursuit: A Comparative Study of the East and West

理想社會與其實踐：東西方歷史的跨文化對話

Sponsored by University of Notre Dame (Franco Family Institute, Ansari Institute for Global Engagement with Religion, the Kellogg Institute for International Studies, Notre Dame Global, the Medieval Institute)

Location: Notre Dame Global Beijing

December 20th – 22nd, 2025

Keynote Talks

Saturday, December 20, 2025

4:00 pm Keynote Talks

Yuri Pines, Michael W. Lipson Professor in Chinese Studies, The Renmin University of China
"Between Utopianism and Realism: Early Chinese Political Thought"

Keith Knapp, Professor of History, The Citadel
"Confucian Utopian Egalitarianism: The Equalization of Fields System (Juntian zhi 均田制) and Its Ideological Origins"
Dinner: 6:30 pm

Sunday, December 21, 2025

Breakfast: Kunlun Hotel

9:00 am - 10:20 am

Panel 1 - From Utopia Models to Early History

Chair: Jinyu Liu

- **Liang Cai**, Ruth and Paul Idzik Associate Professor in Digital Scholarship, University of Notre Dame — *“Utopia, Paranoia, and Collective Lies: The Perils of the Mandate of Heaven in Early Chinese Empires”*
- **Chloe Balla**, Associate Professor of Ancient Philosophy, University of Crete — *“From Utopias to Models: Early Greek Reflections”*

Coffee Break (20 minutes)

10:40 am - 12:00pm

Panel 2 - Imagined Land in Antiquity and Early Medieval China

Chair:

- **Jinyu Liu**, Betty Gage Holland Professor of Roman History, Emory University — *“The Gendered Aspects of the Locus Amoenus and Utopia”*
- **Zhao Lu**, Associate Professor of Global China Studies, NYU Shanghai — *“Peace, Drugs, and Yellow Turbans: How an Eschatological Pathology Came into Being in 3rd Century CE China”*

Lunch Break (12:00 pm -2:00pm)

2:00 pm - 3:20pm

Panel 3 - Utopianism in Practice in Medieval World

Chair: Guangyi Li

- **Ya Zuo**, Associate Professor of History, University of California, Santa Barbara — *“Too Emotional for Utopia: Taming Women for the Ideal World”*
- **Alexander Beihammer**, Heiden Family College Professor, University of Notre Dame — *“Utopia at the Twilight of Empire: Eurasian Ideas of Political Reorganization and Order in the Time around the Fall of Constantinople (1453)”*

Coffee Break 20 minutes

3:40-5:00 pm

Panel 4 - Utopia in Literature and in Theory of Medieval West

Chair: Zhao Lu

- **Guangyi Li**, Professor, Chongqing University— *Heaven upon Blood and Iron: War and Peace in Thomas More’s Utopia*
- **Azfar Moin**, Associate Professor of History, University of Texas at Austin — *“The Mughal Imperial Utopia of ‘Total Peace’ and Its Western Reception”*

Dinner: 6:30 pm

Monday, December 22, 2025

Breakfast: Kunlun Hotel

9:00 am -11:00 am

Panel 4 - Utopia Ideal and Its Pursuit in Later Imperial China

Chair: Liang Cai

- **Ying Zhang**, Professor, Leiden University, To Jail, or Not to Jail: Living with the Utopian Structure in Ming Bureaucratic Management
- **Federico Brusadelli**, Assistant Professor of Chinese History, University of Naples “L’Orientale” — *“Imagining the World as One: Kang Youwei’s Planetary Utopia and the ‘Modernization’ of Confucian Universalism”*
- **Paul Hösle**, Visiting Research Student, Academy of Korean Studies, and **Vittorio Hösle**, Paul Kimball Professor of Arts and Letters, University of Notre Dame — *“The Dialectic of Moral Progress and Material Development in Western Philosophy from the 18th to the 20th Century, with a View on Kang Youwei”*

Break (20 minutes)

11:20 am - 12:40 pm

Panel 5: Utopianism in Modern Day

Chair: Ya Zuo

- **Levi Checketts**, Associate Professor of Religion and Philosophy, Hong Kong Baptist University — *“An Aesthetic Way of Life? Marcuse’s Utopian Hope and the Obstacle of Repression”*
- **Alex Hsu**, Assistant Teaching Professor of Global Affairs, University of Notre Dame — *“A No-Place Like Home: Academic Engaged Buddhism in the Present Progressive”*

Lunch Break (12:40 pm - 2:00 pm)

2:00 pm - 4:00 pm

Panel 6 Utopia Region in Contemporary Societies

Chair: Levi Checketts

- **Simon Wolfgang Fuchs**: Associate Professor of Islam in South Asia and the Middle East, The Hebrew University of Jerusalem—“Is the Middle East the Last Utopian Region on Earth?”
- **Shiping Hua**, Calvin and Helen Lang Distinguished Chair in Asian Studies and Director of the Asian Studies Program, University of Louisville — *“Chinese Utopianism in Modern Times: a ‘Better Place,’ or a ‘No Place’?”*
- **Ori Tavor**, Senior Lecturer in Chinese Philosophy and Religion, University of Pennsylvania— *“Peach Blossom Spring Reimagined: ‘Pocket Utopias’ in Contemporary Chinese Society”*